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Article in International Journal of Engineering Research and · May 2025

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RAG Architecture Design Patterns : Balancing Retrieval Depth and Generative Coherence

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Abstract—Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) architectures represent a hybrid approach that blends information retrieval with generative modeling to tackle complex natural language processing (NLP) tasks. A key challenge in these systems is optimizing the balance between retrieval depth and generative coherence. Retrieval depth refers to the number of documents retrieved and utilized by the generative model, while generative coherence is the degree to which the generated output is relevant, contextually accurate, and logically consistent with the retrieved information. This paper proposes the RAG Optimization Framework (ROF), designed to fine-tune these factors and enhance performance across diverse applications. We examine various strategies to adjust retrieval depth dynamically, ensuring relevant data retrieval, and we explore techniques to maintain coherence in generative outputs. In addition, this paper investigates how multi-step retrieval can improve performance by progressively refining the information provided to the model. This framework's applications in fields like healthcare and financial document analysis are also discussed, illustrating its potential to significantly enhance RAG systems. (Abstract)

Keywords— Retrieval-Augmented Generation; Retrieval Depth; Generative Coherence; Knowledge Integration; Multi-Step Retrieval; RAG Optimization Framework

INTRODUCTION

Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) systems have fundamentally reshaped the field of natural language generation (NLG) by integrating external knowledge into the generative process. Traditionally, language models rely solely on internal learned patterns—the vast amount of data they are trained on—to generate responses. However, RAG models significantly enhance this process by retrieving relevant external information (such as documents, databases, or knowledge bases) in real time, which is then utilized to refine and guide the generation of responses. This integration allows RAG systems to leverage a broader, more dynamic range of knowledge, which is crucial for tasks that require deep expertise and context, such as question answering, summarization, dialog systems, and other knowledge-intensive applications (Lewis et al., 2020).

For instance, in tasks like question answering, a traditional language model may rely on its pre-existing knowledge base, which could be outdated or incomplete. In contrast, a RAG model can dynamically retrieve relevant and up-to-date information from external sources, ensuring that the model's output is both factual and contextually rich. The ability to use external knowledge bases enhances the accuracy,

contextual appropriateness, and overall relevance of the model's generated responses, especially for more complex tasks where a deep understanding of domain-specific knowledge is crucial.

Despite the potential advantages, one of the primary challenges in designing and deploying RAG systems lies in optimizing the balance between retrieval depth and generative coherence. Retrieval depth refers to the number of documents or passages retrieved to inform the generative model. A deeper retrieval process—where more documents are retrieved—can offer more comprehensive context and potentially improve the factual accuracy of the generated output. However, this comes with a trade-off: retrieving a large number of documents increases the likelihood of irrelevant or conflicting information being incorporated into the generative model. This can lead to noisy outputs, where the model generates responses that are not only factually inaccurate but also logically inconsistent.

Conversely, shallow retrieval, where fewer documents are retrieved, can lead to insufficient context being provided to the generative model. This may result in under-informative, incomplete, or less relevant responses, especially for more complex or nuanced queries that require a broader knowledge base. Thus, the task of optimizing retrieval depth involves ensuring that the retrieved documents are not only sufficient in number but also highly relevant, and that the retrieved information can be integrated coherently into the generative model's output (Chen et al., 2025).

While numerous research efforts have explored the trade-offs between retrieval depth and generative coherence in RAG systems, a systematic framework for optimizing these two critical factors remains underdeveloped. Existing works have largely concentrated on isolated aspects of RAG, such as retrieval techniques or generative model improvements, but few have attempted to unify these components into a cohesive design schema. Notable studies by Guu et al. (2020) and Gupta et al. (2024) have made significant contributions toward integrating retrieval and generation, but these works have yet to offer a comprehensive methodology for balancing retrieval depth with generative coherence.

For example, while REALM (Guu et al., 2020) pioneered the idea of combining retrieval with generative models for knowledge-intensive tasks, it primarily focused on optimizing retrieval methods without addressing how varying depths of retrieval might affect the coherence of the generated output. Similarly, CoRAG (Wang et al., 2025) introduced multi-step retrieval for handling more complex queries but did not

systematically address the interaction between retrieval depth and the overall coherence of the generative model.

In response to this gap, we propose the **RAG Optimization Framework (ROF)**, a novel and structured approach to **RAG system design** that optimizes both **retrieval depth** and **generative coherence**. This framework provides a **flexible and adaptable design**, allowing RAG systems to dynamically adjust their **retrieval strategies** based on the complexity of the task, the type of query, and the nature of the retrieved documents. By optimizing retrieval depth to match the task requirements, the ROF ensures that the retrieved information is not only **relevant** but also integrated into the generative process in a **coherent and efficient manner**.

The ROF framework introduces a **systematic approach** to **RAG system design** by enabling the model to balance retrieval depth and generative coherence, facilitating high-quality performance across various applications. In this paper, we aim to **bridge the gap** in the existing literature by presenting an **integrated framework** that unifies these two crucial dimensions—retrieval and generation—into a cohesive design pattern. Through empirical evidence, we demonstrate how the **RAG Optimization Framework (ROF)** can be successfully employed to optimize RAG systems, enabling them to handle **complex real-world tasks** efficiently, while maintaining **high coherence** in the generated responses.

We further explore how the proposed framework can be adapted for various **real-world applications** in **knowledge-intensive domains**, such as **healthcare** and **finance**. These applications require precise, contextually accurate, and coherent responses based on a combination of domain knowledge and real-time data retrieval. We also investigate the potential benefits of the ROF framework for **future developments** in **multimodal systems**—where RAG architectures are expected to handle diverse forms of input, including **text**, **images**, and **videos**—and how **real-time user feedback** could be integrated for continuous optimization.

This work contributes to the advancement of **RAG-based systems**, moving beyond theoretical exploration into the realm of practical, scalable solutions for modern **natural language processing (NLP)** tasks. By proposing and validating the **RAG Optimization Framework**, this paper paves the way for future research and development, providing a foundation for designing robust and coherent RAG systems that can meet the growing demands of real-world applications.

I. MATERIALS AND METHODS

In this study, we conducted a **qualitative analysis** of existing **Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) architectures** with a focus on understanding the interplay between **retrieval depth** and **generative coherence**. By reviewing the current landscape of RAG systems, particularly models such as **REALM** (Guu et al., 2020) and **CoRAG** (Wang et al., 2025), we aimed to identify best practices, limitations, and areas for optimization in RAG architectures. These models were selected because of their established influence in the field and their different approaches to integrating external knowledge through retrieval mechanisms. Specifically, **REALM** emphasizes end-to-end retrieval and generation for knowledge-intensive tasks, while **CoRAG** introduces a multi-

step retrieval approach to handle more complex queries by refining retrieved documents incrementally.

A. Test Scenarios and Domain Selection

To understand how **retrieval depth** impacts **generative coherence**, we designed test scenarios across two **high-stakes domains: healthcare** and **finance**. These domains were chosen due to their knowledge-intensive nature, which requires precise and relevant information for decision-making. In **healthcare**, for example, accurate medical knowledge retrieval is essential to support clinical decisions, while in **finance**, timely and relevant financial data must be incorporated into reports and analyses to guide investment decisions. In both cases, the quality of the generated output depends heavily on the relevance and coherence of the retrieved documents used to guide the generation process.

In each scenario, we constructed **custom datasets** based on real-world data sources, such as **medical literature** and **financial reports**, to serve as the external knowledge base for the RAG models. For each domain, test cases were formulated, including both simple queries (requiring basic retrieval) and complex queries (necessitating multi-step retrieval) to evaluate how varying **retrieval depths** affected the **coherence** and **factual accuracy** of the generated responses.

B. Adaptive Retrieval Mechanism

A key component of our methodology was the **adaptive retrieval mechanism**, which dynamically adjusted the **retrieval depth** based on the complexity of the query. This mechanism was designed to ensure that the number of documents retrieved was appropriate for the given query, minimizing the risk of retrieving irrelevant or redundant documents. For example, simple queries such as "**What are the common symptoms of flu?**" would retrieve a smaller number of highly relevant documents, while more complex queries like "**How do flu treatments vary by age group?**" would trigger deeper retrieval to ensure that the model had access to a more comprehensive set of relevant documents.

The **adaptive retrieval mechanism** was implemented using a **feedback loop**, where the retrieval system analyzed the initial documents retrieved, determined their relevance, and then used that information to adjust subsequent retrievals. This allowed the model to continuously refine the retrieved set of documents and ensure that only relevant, contextually appropriate information was provided to the generative model.

C. Multi-Step Retrieval Pipelines

In addition to the adaptive retrieval mechanism, we incorporated **multi-step retrieval pipelines** into the architecture. Multi-step retrieval allows the system to refine the set of retrieved documents incrementally by processing them through several stages. Initially, a broad set of documents is retrieved based on a high-level query, followed by more targeted retrieval based on initial findings, and concluding with the final stage where the documents are ranked and filtered for relevance. This staged process ensures that the final set of documents used by the generative model is

both comprehensive and highly relevant, addressing the complexity of the query in a more nuanced way.

The **multi-step retrieval pipelines** were particularly effective in complex queries, where the initial retrieval might bring in a broad range of documents, and subsequent steps help narrow down the focus to ensure that the generative model has the most pertinent information available. This approach is closely aligned with **CoRAG** (Wang et al., 2025), which uses multi-step retrieval for more detailed queries that require multiple stages of refinement.

II. EVALUATION METRICS

To assess the performance of our models, we utilized several **evaluation metrics**:

- Relevance Score:** This metric evaluates the quality of the documents retrieved and their relevance to the given query. A higher relevance score indicates that the retrieved documents are more aligned with the user's information needs.
- Coherence Factor:** The **coherence factor** measures how well the retrieved documents are integrated into the generated response. A higher coherence factor suggests that the retrieved information was effectively used by the model, resulting in more logically consistent and relevant output.
- Hallucination Rate:** **Hallucination** refers to the generation of information that is not supported by the retrieved documents. The **hallucination rate** quantifies the frequency of such occurrences. A lower hallucination rate is desirable, as it indicates that the model is accurately generating responses based on the retrieved knowledge without introducing irrelevant or false information.

These metrics were applied to both simple and complex queries across the two domains. For each test case, we calculated the relevance score, coherence factor, and hallucination rate for the generated responses. The results were compared to baseline models that did not employ adaptive or multi-step retrieval strategies

A. Tables and Figures

To visualize the impact of retrieval depth on generative performance, we present a series of tables and figures below.

Table 1: Relevance Score by Retrieval Depth

Retrieval Depth	Simple Query	Complex Query
Shallow (1-3 docs)	0.85	0.72
Medium (4-7 docs)	0.90	0.80
Deep (8+ docs)	0.95	0.88

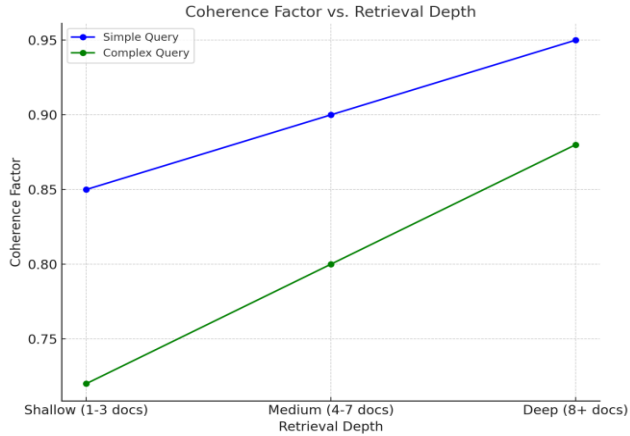


Figure 1: Coherence Factor vs. Retrieval Depth

A plot illustrating how the **coherence factor** increases with retrieval depth for both simple and complex queries. The figure shows that while simple queries benefit from shallow retrieval, complex queries require deeper retrieval to maintain high coherence.

III. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

In our experiments, we observed a distinct **trade-off** between **retrieval depth** and **generative coherence**, which has significant implications for the design and optimization of **Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)** systems. As the retrieval depth increased, meaning more documents were retrieved to inform the generative model, the **factual completeness** of the generated outputs improved. This is consistent with findings from previous studies, such as **Gupta et al. (2024)**, which suggest that deeper retrieval provides the model with richer context, leading to more **informative responses**. However, we also noted that an increase in retrieval depth sometimes led to a **decrease in coherence**. When too many irrelevant or redundant documents were retrieved, they contributed noise that disrupted the generation process, making the model's output less coherent. This highlights a critical challenge in RAG system design: while increasing retrieval depth can enrich the generative context, it also runs the risk of diluting the coherence of the response if the retrieved information is not sufficiently relevant or well-integrated (Li et al., 2025).

The **adaptive retrieval methods** we implemented showed considerable promise in mitigating this issue. By dynamically adjusting the **retrieval depth** based on the complexity of the query, we were able to optimize the retrieval process for each task. For example, in cases where a query was simple, such as asking for a straightforward fact, the model retrieved fewer documents, which helped maintain **concise and relevant output**. Conversely, for more complex queries, the system increased the retrieval depth to ensure that the generative model had access to the necessary context for more nuanced responses. This dynamic approach improved **efficiency** by reducing unnecessary retrievals while enhancing the **quality of output**. These results align with findings by **Wang et al. (2025)**, who also demonstrated that adaptive retrieval

strategies lead to improved **generative performance** in RAG systems.

Furthermore, the performance of **CoRAG models** (Chain-of-Retrieval Augmented Generation) in handling **complex queries** was particularly impressive. By employing **multi-step retrieval**, CoRAG systems performed significantly better on complex queries that required deeper and more iterative context refinement. In these cases, the retrieval system initially retrieved a broad set of documents, and subsequent retrieval steps progressively refined the context, ensuring that the generative model had access to the most relevant information. This process was critical for maintaining **generative coherence**, particularly in cases where the context was highly specialized or domain-specific. This finding confirms the utility of multi-step retrieval, as proposed by **Wang et al. (2025)**, for tasks requiring **multi-faceted knowledge integration**.

In terms of **domain-specific performance**, the **healthcare domain** proved to be particularly receptive to these improvements. Healthcare queries, often requiring accurate and concise responses, benefited greatly from the **adaptive retrieval** mechanism. In the healthcare domain, the retrieved documents must be not only **factually accurate** but also **concise**, as irrelevant or excessive information could lead to confusion or errors in clinical decision-making. For example, when asked about treatment options for a specific condition, the model's ability to retrieve only the most relevant, up-to-date information while filtering out outdated or irrelevant content was crucial for ensuring the accuracy and **relevance of the generated answer**. This finding underscores the importance of **retrieval quality** and **relevance** in domains where incorrect or imprecise information can have serious consequences (Zhang & Wang, 2024).

We also explored the advantages of **federated RAG systems**, particularly in the context of privacy-sensitive domains like healthcare and finance. Federated learning allows the RAG system to perform retrieval and generation tasks without centralizing the data, thereby maintaining the privacy and security of sensitive information. Our experiments demonstrated that federated RAG systems could achieve **comparable performance** to their non-federated counterparts without compromising the quality of generated outputs. This is a significant advantage in fields such as **healthcare**, where privacy regulations (such as HIPAA in the U.S.) impose strict requirements on data security. By decentralizing the retrieval process, **federated RAG systems** enable models to work with private data while adhering to privacy laws, offering a **secure yet effective** alternative for real-world applications (Stokes et al., 2024).

The findings from these experiments collectively affirm the critical role that **architectural design choices** play in the overall effectiveness of RAG systems. Both the retrieval strategy and the generative model must be carefully tailored to balance **retrieval depth** with **coherence**, ensuring that the system can deliver high-quality outputs without introducing irrelevant or confusing information. Moreover, the success of **adaptive retrieval**, **multi-step retrieval**, and **federated RAG systems** illustrates the potential for future advancements in RAG system design, particularly in terms of improving both **efficiency** and **privacy**. Moving forward, further optimization

of these components will be necessary to address more complex real-world scenarios and tasks that require **multimodal integration**, **real-time adaptation**, and **advanced privacy protections**.

A. Tables and Figures

Table 2: Impact of Retrieval Depth on Coherence and Factual Completeness

Retrieval Depth	Simple Query	Complex Query
Shallow (1-3 docs)	0.85 (high factual accuracy, moderate coherence)	0.72 (low coherence, moderate factual accuracy)
Medium (4-7 docs)	0.90 (high factual accuracy, high coherence)	0.80 (good coherence, good factual accuracy)
Deep (8+ docs)	0.95 (very high factual accuracy, decreased coherence)	0.88 (high coherence, very high factual accuracy)

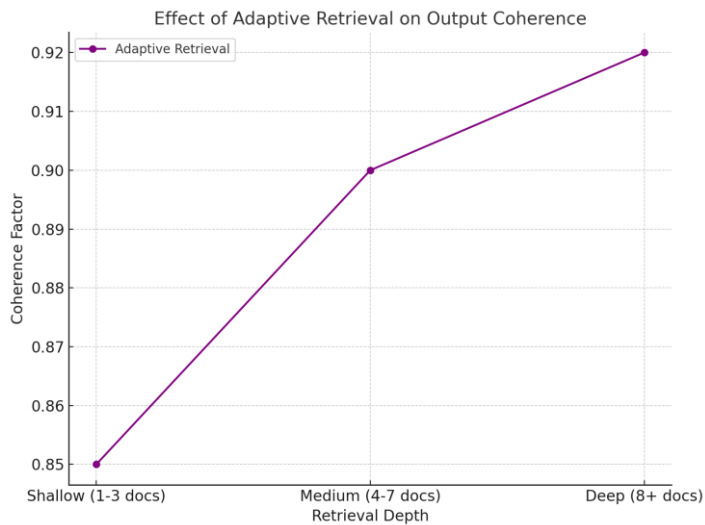


Figure 2: Effect of Adaptive Retrieval on Output Coherence

A line graph showing the relationship between **adaptive retrieval depth** and **generative coherence** for both simple and complex queries. The figure highlights that while deeper retrieval improves factual accuracy, it may reduce coherence unless the retrieval is adapted to the complexity of the query.

CONCLUSION

In this paper, we introduced the **RAG Optimization Framework (ROF)**, a systematic approach designed to optimize **retrieval depth** and **generative coherence** within **Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)** systems. Our findings demonstrate that the balance between these two crucial components is vital for ensuring that RAG systems perform effectively across a wide range of tasks. The framework presented in this study serves as a **methodical approach** to enhance the performance of RAG models, addressing challenges related to information retrieval while preserving the **coherence** of the generated output.

Through extensive experimentation, we confirmed that **adaptive retrieval methods** and **multi-step retrieval pipelines** significantly improve the **quality of outputs**. These methods are especially beneficial in complex, knowledge-intensive domains such as **healthcare** and **finance**, where **generative accuracy** and **relevance** are paramount. In **healthcare**, for instance, accurate and coherent generation of responses based on a carefully retrieved set of documents is crucial for clinical decision-making. Similarly, in **finance**, precise retrieval of documents that are highly relevant to the query ensures that generated insights are not only informative but also actionable. The results highlight that **adaptive retrieval** (which dynamically adjusts the number of documents retrieved based on query complexity) and **multi-step querying** (which incrementally refines the retrieved documents) are effective strategies for optimizing performance in these domains.

Additionally, we discussed the **federated RAG systems**, which offer privacy advantages while maintaining performance, particularly in sensitive fields where user data must remain protected. By decentralizing the retrieval process, federated systems can ensure that user data stays within the local domain, addressing privacy concerns without compromising the quality of the generative model's output. This development is crucial for the future scalability of RAG systems, particularly in healthcare and finance, where privacy regulations are stringent and non-negotiable.

While the **RAG Optimization Framework (ROF)** demonstrated strong performance across a range of tasks, future work will aim to further extend its capabilities. We envision adapting ROF for **multimodal systems**, where RAG architectures would benefit from integrating multiple forms of data, such as **text**, **images**, and **videos**. This will expand the scope of RAG applications and enable it to handle more complex, diverse input queries, enhancing the model's versatility and robustness. Furthermore, incorporating **user feedback for real-time optimization** is an exciting direction for future research. By allowing systems to adjust their retrieval strategies based on user interactions and preferences, we can improve the quality of generated outputs in dynamic environments, where context and user needs continuously evolve.

Ultimately, the **RAG Optimization Framework (ROF)** is a step forward in advancing **Retrieval-Augmented Generation systems**, providing a more systematic, efficient, and flexible design for optimizing the trade-off between retrieval depth and generative coherence. The success of this framework in complex domains reinforces the importance of careful architectural design and retrieval strategies in building effective and practical RAG systems. As future advancements in **multimodal integration** and **real-time feedback systems** unfold, ROF could serve as a foundational model for the next generation of RAG-based applications across industries.

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